As Is

By William M. Hoffman

1st MAN: **(Pg 30)** The first time I heard about AIDS was in the Paradise Garage, a disco I used to go to. I won a raffle, the proceeds of which went to help people with this strange new disease. I didn't even know what it was.

2nd MAN: I thought AIDS was like Legionnaires ' Disease, or Toxic Shock Syndrome, or Sickle-cell Anemia, Alzheimer's Disease – one of those rare diseases you read about in the papers.

INTRODUCTION

In 1981, the first cases of AIDS were reported. According to the CDC, by December 31, 2000 nearly 450,000 people in the United States had died. See . . . In the 1980's AIDS was poorly understood by the general public. It was a disease stigmatized as an illness impacting primarily the gay community and there was no known treatment. This selection follows two gay men in the early 1980s dealing not only with the AIDS epidemic but also with the fear that swept through our society at the time. As Is by William M. Hoffman.

SAUL: **(Pg 16-17)** I visited Teddy today at St. Vincent's. It's very depressing . . . He's lying there in bed, out of it. He doesn't even know you're there. *(Pause)* Jimmy died, as you must have heard. I went out to San Francisco to be with him the last few weeks. He was in a coma for a month. Everybody wanted to pull the plug, but they were afraid of legal complications. I held his hand. He couldn't talk, but I could see his eyelids flutter. I swear he knew I was with him. *(Pause)* I haven't slept well for weeks. Every morning I examine my body for swellings, marks. I'm terrified of every pimple, every rash. If I cough I think of Teddy. I wish he would die. He **is** dead. He might as well be. Why can't he die? *(Beat)* Say something, damn it.

RICH: I have it.

DOCTOR 1: We call it a "Pre-AIDS Condition"

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DOCTOR 2: "AIDS-related Complex"

SAUL: I don't think that's funny.

RICH: That's the bad news. The good news is that I have only the swollen glands . . . and I've lost some weight. **(Pg 18-19)** I tire easily. My temperature goes up and down.

SAUL: Doctors make mistakes all the time. Remember when they told my niece she had skin cancer? It turned out to be dry skin.

TV ANNOUNCER: **(Pg 20)** The simple fact is, that we know very little about Acquired Immune Deficiency Syndrome. Its victims may live a normal life span, or they may have only a few weeks. Fortunately, so far this tragic disease has mainly been confined to the high-risk groups and has rarely affected people like you and me. When will science conquer this dreaded plague? We don't know. We simply don't know . .

SAUL: You're my friend. You'll stay with me till you feel better.

RICH: **(Pg 21)** Aren't you afraid I'll infect you? Paper plates, Lysol, face masks – no. I'd prefer to live alone, thank you. . . Besides, if I live with you, where am I going to bring my tricks?

SAUL: You pick up people?

RICH: *(Sarcastically)* I lurk in dark corners where they can't see my lumps. I'm like a shark or a barracuda, and I snap them up and infect them.

SAUL: How can you joke about this?

RICH: I don't care. I'm going to die! I'll take as many as I can with me. And I've pissed in the Croton Reservoir. I'm going to infect the whole city! Wheee!

SAUL: **(PG 22)** Give me a straight answer. Do you still pick up people?

RICH: Maybe I ought to wear a sign around my neck and ring a bell. "AIDS. I've got AIDS, stand clear!" Would that make you happy? Or maybe I should dig a hole in the ground, douse myself with kerosene, and have a final cigarette. No muss, no

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fuss. Is that what you want?

SAUL: Forgive me for not trusting you. It's just that I'm frightened of it.

RICH: How do you think I feel? My lover leaves me;

CHET: **(Pg 18)** If you don't mind, I'll sleep on the couch tonight. You've been sweating a lot. **(Pg 19)** I know I'm being paranoid. *(Rich reaches out to Chet)* **(Pg 20)** Don't touch me!

RICH: **(Pg 22)** My family won't let me near them;

BROTHER: **(Pg 18)** I'm not in the habit of kissing my brother. I touched him on the back when I arrived and when I left. **(Pg 19)** Christ, I didn't even use the bathroom.

RICH: **(Pg 22)** I lose my business;

PARTNER: **(Pg 18)** Rich and I started [this catering] business about a year ago. But now word got out that Rich has this disease. I tried to explain: he doesn't touch the food; I do all the cooking. But they won't listen. I can understand what he's going through. Myself, I've been wrestling with cancer for a while.

RICH: **(Pg 22)** I can't pay my rent. How do you think I feel?

SAUL: You'll stay here with me. You have nowhere to go. You've got to stay with me. *(Pause)* You were kidding about picking up people.

RICH: **(PG 31)** Just until I feel better. . . **(Pg 32)** One thing. I'm embarrassed. I'm just about broke. The doctors. Tests.

SAUL: We'll get by. You'll see.

RICH: I'll keep track of every cent you spend on me. You'll get it all back when I can work. I swear. . . . Saul, I'm frightened. *(Saul takes him in his arms)*

SAUL: We'll be okay. We'll be okay.

********** **CUT TO AIDS SUPPORT GROUP (PWA=Person with AIDS)** **********

PWA: **(Pg 37-38)** I was part of a team trying to teach robots how to use language. *(He*

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moves and talks like a robot) "I'm Harris, your android model 3135X. I can vacuum the floors, cook cheeseburgers, play the piano." It's much harder to teach robots to understand. *(Instructing a backward robot)* Joke?

ROBOT: Noun: a clash of values or levels of reality, producing laughter. Example: Have you heard about the disease attacking Jewish American princesses? It's called MAIDS. You die if you don't get it. Ha. Ha.

PWA: My co-workers asked me to leave. They were afraid of contracting AIDS through the air, or by my looking at them. You see, they are scientists. My last act before I left was programming one final robot. *(He behaves like a robot again)* "Good morning. This is Jack – *(He suddenly becomes a flamboyantly gay robot)* but you can call me Jackie – your fabulous new android model 1069. If you wish to use me – and I love being used – press one of those cunning little buttons on my pecs. Go on, press one – *(He switches from a campy tone to an almost angry, accusatory one)* or are you afraid of me too?" That was my stab at immortality.

RICH: I'm not sure I have it anymore. I feel like somehow I'm being disloyal to the group. (but) I'm getting better, I know it. I just have these lumps, which for some reason won't go away. I feel great. I feel the disease disappearing in me. Only a tiny percentage of those with the swollen glands come down with the rest. If I ***really*** thought that I was coming down with it . . . we all have ***options***. . . .

TRANSITION

But Rich was not getting better. The disease progressed rapidly and soon, Saul was visiting Rich in the hospital as they tried desperately to combat the symptoms ravaging his body. Rich began to contemplate his options.

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RICH: **(Pg 47)** Saul, I want you to do something for me. Will you do something for me? Now listen. I want you to go out of here and go to the doctor and tell him you aren't sleeping so hot

SAUL: I'm sleeping okay.

RICH: Sh! Now listen: you tell him you want something to make you sleep and Valium doesn't work on you, but a friend once gave you some Seconal –

SAUL: No! I won't do it!

RICH: *(Pressuring Saul relentlessly)* I tried hoarding the pills here, but every night the nurse stays to watch me swallow them down.

SAUL: I can't do that. I won't listen.

RICH: If you love me, you'll help me. I have something that's eating me up. I don't want to go on. I'm scared to go on.

SAUL: Don't do this to me! I can't handle it. . . I swear, don't do this –

RICH: Don't you see, it's the only way. Just get the pills. Just have them around. You'll get used to the idea. And when the lesions spread above my neck so that I don't look the same, you'll want me to have them. **(Pg 52)** What' so hot about living when you're covered with lesions and you're coming down with a new infection every day? . . . . If it gets too bad, I want to be able to quietly disappear.

SAUL: I won't argue the logic of it. I can't do what you want me do.

RICH: I just want them around. You keep them for me – just in case.

SAUL: I won't

RICH: Then I'll get them myself. *(Tries to get up, but is shaky)* **(Pg 53)** Where're my clothes? *(Takes a few steps)*

SAUL: Get back in bed! *(Tries to help steady Rich)*

RICH: I want to get out of here! *(Fighting Saul)* This place is a death machine! *(He collapses on the floor)*

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SAUL: *(sits beside him)* You idiot . . . I want you to understand something. It's important. Listen. **(Pg 54)** Don't you see, I just don't have the right to take your life. Maybe I'm being selfish, but I want you here. **(Pg 52)** Let me help you live!

RICH: My future isn't exactly promising. **(Pg 48-49)** I have Kaposi's sarcoma, a hitherto rare form of skin cancer. It's spreading. I have just begun chemotherapy. It nauseates me. I expect my hair will fall out. I also have a fungal infection of the throat called candidiasis, or thrush. My life expectancy is . . . I have a greater chance of winning the lottery.

SAUL: **(Pg 54)** I'll take you as is.

RICH: But what happens when it gets worse? It's gonna get worse.

SAUL: I'll be here for you no matter what happens. I promise.

RICH: Shit. You're so goddamned noble.

SAUL: How do you want me to be?

RICH: I can't afford to be noble. The only thing holding me together is rage. It's not fair! Why me?

SAUL: Why not you? Maybe it's me next. No one knows.

RICH: I reserve the right to put an end to all this shit.

SAUL: All right, but if you kill yourself they won't bury you in hallowed ground and you'll got to hell with all us Jews.

RICH: I bet they have a separate AIDS section in the cemetery so I don't infect the other corpses. *(Beat. Then suddenly he speaks fiercely)* Do you promise to stick with me no matter what happens?

SAUL: I do.

RICH: Do you? *(He searches Saul's face for the answer)* I need you. *(Long silence. Rich exits scene as Hospice worker steps forward to address the audience)*

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HOSPICE WORKER: **(Pg 56-57)** I have a new AIDS patient, Richard. He still has a lot of denial about his condition. Which is normal. I think most of us would go crazy if we had to face our own deaths squarely. Rich will be out of the hospital again in a week or so. For a while. He's a fighter . . . The angry phase is just about over and the bargaining phase is beginning. If he behaves like a good little boy, God will do what Rich tells Him to do . . . I certainly hope that God does.

CLOSING

*In the US today; research, education and treatment options have converted AIDS from a certain death sentence to a condition that can be managed. According to the Kaiser Family Foundation . . . over 1.2 million people in the US today are **LIVING** with HIV/AIDS. We have a long way to go . . . Minority populations and rural areas of the US are still more profoundly affected than the rest of the county. But progress is being made. The panic of the 1980's has ended and today, people are being more readily accepted AS IS.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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